

The Google Business Profile Checklist for Accommodation Operators

25 things to fix on your Google listing so guests book direct — not through Booking.com.

Booking.com and the other OTAs charge you 15–25% per booking. That's \$25,000+ a year for a small motel like the one we work with up the road in Mallacoota.

Your Google Business Profile is the single biggest free tool you have to win those bookings back. Most operators have it set up wrong — or barely set up at all. This checklist fixes that.

Tick each box as you go. It'll take you about an hour. Print it, scribble on it, do whatever works.

1. Foundation

THE BASICS — GET THESE WRONG AND NOTHING ELSE MATTERS

☐ Claim and verify your listing

If Google doesn't trust you own the business, you can't edit anything. Search your business name on Google and look for "Own this business?"

☐ Business name matches your real signage

No keyword stuffing. "Sunset Motel Best Beach Accommodation" gets you suspended.

☐ Address is correct and consistent

It must match exactly what's on your website, your invoices, and any directory listings.

☐ Phone number is your direct line

Not a forwarding number, not Booking.com's tracking line. Your number, that you answer.

☐ Website link points to your own site

Not your Booking.com page. Your domain, your booking engine.

2. Categories & Attributes

TELL GOOGLE EXACTLY WHAT YOU ARE

- ☐ **Primary category set correctly**
"Motel," "Hotel," "Holiday home rental agency," "Bed & Breakfast," "Cabin rental agency" — pick the most specific one.
 - ☐ **Add 2–4 secondary categories**
Add things like "Tourist attraction," "Wedding venue," "Conference centre" if they apply. Don't pad with stuff that isn't true.
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- ☐ **Tick every relevant amenity**
Wi-Fi, parking, pet-friendly, family rooms, pool, BBQ, kitchenette — guests filter by these.
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- ☐ **Set accessibility attributes honestly**
Step-free entrance, accessible parking, accessible bathroom. Travellers actively search for these.

3. Hours & Contact

NO SURPRISES FOR GUESTS

- ☐ **Check-in and check-out hours set**
If guests can call 24/7, set hours to "Open 24 hours." If not, list reception hours.
 - ☐ **Public holidays and seasonal closures added**
Use the "Special hours" feature for Easter, Christmas, off-season closures.
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- ☐ **Description fills the full 750 characters**
Plain English. Mention your town, what makes you different, and what guests get.

4. Photos

THIS IS WHERE MOST OPERATORS LOSE THE BOOKING

- ☐ **Logo uploaded (square, high-res)**
Square format, minimum 720×720px.
 - ☐ **Cover photo is your best exterior shot**
Daylight, wide angle, no people walking through the frame.
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- ☐ **At least 10 interior photos uploaded**
Every room type, bathroom, kitchen if you have one. Beds made, blinds open, lights on.
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- ☐ **Outdoor and surrounds covered**
Pool, garden, beach access, view from the balcony — what people are actually buying.
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- ☐ **Add a new photo at least monthly**
Google rewards active listings. Even a sunset shot from the deck counts.

5. The Direct Booking Bit

WHERE THE COMMISSION SAVINGS ACTUALLY HAPPEN

- ☐ **Reservation link goes to your own booking engine**
In the GBP dashboard, set "Reservations" to your direct booking URL — not Booking.com or Airbnb.
 - ☐ **Menu / services link added (if applicable)**
For motels with restaurants or accommodation packages, list them under "Services."
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- ☐ **Messaging turned on**
Lets guests text you directly from search results. Big trust signal. Be ready to reply within a few hours.

Why this matters

Google now lets travellers book direct from the search results. If your reservation link points at your own site, you keep 100% of that booking. If it points at Booking.com, you've just paid commission on a booking Google sent you for free.

6. Reviews

YOUR MOST POWERFUL CONVERSION TOOL

- ☐ **Reply to every review — good and bad**
Within 48 hours. Personalised, by name. Never copy-paste the same reply.
 - ☐ **Set up a review request system**
Send guests your Google review link by SMS or email the morning of checkout. Aim for one new review per week minimum.
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- ☐ **Get your short Google review link**
In your GBP dashboard, click "Ask for reviews" — copy that link, save it, use it everywhere.

7. Posts & Q&A

FREE REAL ESTATE MOST OPERATORS IGNORE

☐ **Post an update every 2–4 weeks**

Local events, seasonal specials, new amenities, photos of the area. Counts as a fresh signal to Google.

☐ **Pre-load the Q&A section**

Add the questions guests actually ask — pet policy, parking, late check-in — and answer them yourself. Saves you replying to the same enquiry 50 times.

Done it all? Here's what's next.

If you've ticked every box, your Google Business Profile is now in better shape than 95% of accommodation listings in your town. Want a hand keeping more of those bookings direct instead of handing 15-20% to Booking.com? Get in touch — find me on Facebook or Instagram as Your Mate Agency, or my email and number are right below.

Your Mate Agency — helping regional businesses get found online.

Built by Matt Rowlands in Mallacoota, East Gippsland.

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